Read/listen to the article by Hutson (2021) in Nature on Robo-writers. This week, post your thoughts on the risks and benefits of the use AI writers at different levels, from administrative work to creative writing.
You should demonstrate that you understand the topic covered and ensure you use references to academic literature (journals, books, reports, etc.).

Learning Outcomes

- Apply and critically appraise machine learning techniques to real-world problems, particularly where technical risk and uncertainty is involved.

Initial Post

The benefits of using AI writers at different levels vary according to context, in my view. For simple administrative tasks – e.g. generating a simple set of clear and unambiguous instructions for a task - can be done quickly with an AI prompt, as opposed to spending time carefully considering what words to use and how to phrase something. AI can advise me on my grammar and spelling, as MS Word has done for decades, but it can also review my words in context and advise on tone and clarity. These are all things I can do for myself, but where the output is more important than the process, such as in the example I gave above, I'd prefer to spend less time on writing the text and just a short time on editing what AI has suggested.

However, it's clear when a colleague uses AI to generate a simple email as the feel of the text, the "voice" is different. The risk here is that people become incapable of vocalising their thoughts and choosing the right words without assistance. It's also a risk that people will accept whatever is generated by AI, without properly checking it.

Once we move into the realms of more complex thoughts and communications, the danger of losing the human "voice" is even greater. Will the next William Shakespeare simply be the person who came up with the best AI prompt? Will original thought be lost if AI becomes our source of art and literature? Or will AI be able to make leaps of imagination that are beyond the human brain because it has greater experience than any individual and is less constrained by reality?

More specifically, the risks of using AI for writing – be it in simple emails or great works of literature – are that the large language models are a product of their experiences. Just like a person who follows only people who share their own beliefs on social media, the view of AI is coloured by its experience which is not necessarily fully rounded. Hutson (2021) speaks of the dangers of AI having access to both extreme and outdated views and bringing those into its responses as if they are facts. For example, a nurse is assumed to be female.

There is a great dilemma here. We can restrict the data available to AI models so that they don't ingest any prejudiced material. This could lead to the question of whether truly unbiased data even exists. We could ensure that AI receives conflicting data that could enable it to always present a balanced view, but can it be trained to fully provide all viewpoints, rather than the most likely or popular viewpoint?

Part of the problem is that AI responses to prompts currently produce plausible, sensible responses, which can be completely incorrect. (Wachter *et al*., 2024) There is no duty on the LLM to speak only the truth. Its responses are produced using probability, rather than purely genuine research. LLMs speak to us with the authority of an encyclopaedia, making it appear inherently trustworthy. It's a great tool, but we must learn to review, edit and fact-check. Of

course, when every internet search produces an AI response, it becomes harder to fully fact-check and, as humans are always looking for the easiest path, I suspect that due diligence will become a rarity restricted to professional researchers and misinformation will abound.

References:

Hutson, M. (2021) 'The language machines', Nature, 591(7848), pp. 22–25. Available at: https://doi.org/10.1038/d41586-021-00530-0.

Sandra Wachter, Brent Mittelstadt, Chris Russell; Do large language models have a legal duty to tell the truth?. *R. Soc. Open Sci.* 1 August 2024; 11 (8): 240197. https://doi.org/10.1098/rsos.240197